



Gulbarga Fort

Find out about the remains of a once great fort at Gulbarga, and its unique features such as Bala Hissar. <https://digit.in/jul20-83>



The last stand

The epic story of how an army of over one lakh soldiers captured the Maratha hill forts in 1818. <https://digit.in/jul20-84>

music performed here could be heard throughout the fort, or at least till the seat of the royalty. Often, the entrance to the gates were the tallest structures in the city, and the music gallery on top offered panoramic views of the city. The main gate outside the old palace at Kolhapur has such a nagarkhana, and there is another excellently-preserved one at Raigad fort. The entrance itself is called the Nagarkhana gate. The nagarkhana at Kolhapur was at a height of five stories, which was easily well above the height of any other structure nearby. While the name is remembered, people now have forgotten the significance of this structure, and what it was originally used for.

ELEPHANT DOORS

These are tall and massive doors of teak at the main entrance to the forts. Yes, they were big enough to allow elephants to pass, with the howdahs on top where the royals used to be seated, but they were also designed to keep a force of elephants out. Often, the wood was fortified with iron, and just like the doors of our home have cat flaps, these massive doors had smaller doors within them for humans to quickly go in and out. These doors are also studded with iron spikes on the front facing part. Some of the forts had a series of these doors, Gulbarga, for example, has four of them and there are a series of gates at Shivneri as well. If there were two gates, the inner one was often located at right angles to the outer one. If



The Hawa Mahal at Amber

there were a series of gates, the pathway between them had a number of twists and turns to make matters difficult for any invading army. At times, these doors had massive iron chains securing them, which could be locked into place. If chains were not available, then the doors were secured or locked by bars of timber. Typically, there would be guard houses on both sides of the door entrance. The double doors at Seringapatam fort are made of rosewood and inlaid with ivory. In some very rare cases, such as the Basavakalyan fort, the doors are made of blocks of stone.

UNIQUE FEATURES

Some forts have unique features found nowhere else. The Gulbarga fort for example has a cavernous dungeon called the Bala Hissar, the only one among all the forts of India. It was not used to keep prisoners, but was instead a last holdout with

a way that no one can see it till they are almost at it. Above the entrance at Amber fort, there is a pyramidal facade five storeys high known as the Hawa Mahal, which was a viewing gallery designed for the royal ladies, and allowed for a cool breeze to blow through the structure at all times. The coronation hall at Junagarh fort is known as the Raj Tilak Hall and has intricate and elaborate lacquer work along with inlays of opaque glass. At the Sheesh Mahal, the plasters on the walls are embedded with hundreds of tiny mirrors, which gave the illusion of stars in the night sky when the lamps were lit at night. The entrance to Jahangir Mahal is carved from a single massive block of sandstone. The Kaliadeh Mahal has a network of channels and tanks through the main galleries that have water flowing through them, keeping the entire structure cooled at all times. These channels end in a 20 foot tall artificial waterfall. Pratapgarh has a double line of fortifications, with the walls undulating according to the terrain. Lohgarh has a long narrow fortified section with a bastion at the end, which is called vinchukata in Marathi, or the scorpion's tail. This section of the fort is very instagrammable. At Sindhudurg fort is the one of two temples of Shivaji in the country, and it depicts Shivaji without a beard. The other one is at Shivaji's birthplace at Shivneri and is a recent restoration of the house where Shivaji was born. 🇮🇳



Doors to deter attacks by elephants at the Shaniwar Wada fort in Pune

walls of stone. There is only one entrance. The Chitradurga fort is made up of walls having seven concentric circles, which is similar to the layout of the city of Gondor in The Lord of the Rings. While most forts are a formidable, imposing structure, the Basavakalyan fort is hidden in such